COLOSSIANS · STUDY 12 OF 12

Colossians 4:7–18

Portrait of a Ministry Team

Christ Is All — A Study of Colossians

Small Group Bible Study Series · NASB95

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Editor: The Gospel Vault

① Text	② Devotional	③ Commentary	④ Self-Study Guide
Foundation	Personal preparation	Teacher / leader preparation	Group meeting
Everyone	*All group members*	*Teacher / leader*	*Small group*

⑤ *Application closes each study and draws from all sections above.*

Time guide: about 30 minutes — Devotional 4 · Commentary 15 · Discussion 8 · Application 3.

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① BIBLICAL TEXT

Colossians 4:7–18 · New American Standard Bible (NASB95)

4:7 *As to all my affairs, Tychicus, our beloved brother and faithful servant and fellow bond-servant in the Lord, will bring you information.*

8 *For I have sent him to you for this very purpose, that you may know about our circumstances and that he may encourage your hearts;*

9 *and with him Onesimus, our faithful and beloved brother, who is one of your number. They will inform you about the whole situation here.*

10 *Aristarchus, my fellow prisoner, sends you his greetings; and also Barnabas's cousin Mark (about whom you received instructions; if he comes to you, welcome him);*

11 *and also Jesus who is called Justus; these are the only fellow workers for the kingdom of God who are from the circumcision, and they have proved to be an encouragement to me.*

12 *Epaphras, who is one of your number, a bondslave of Jesus Christ, sends you his greetings, always laboring earnestly for you in his prayers, that you may stand perfect and fully assured in all the will of God.*

13 *For I testify for him that he has a deep concern for you and for those who are in Laodicea and Hierapolis.*

14 *Luke, the beloved physician, sends you his greetings, and also Demas.*

15 *Greet the brethren who are in Laodicea and also Nympha and the church that is in her house.*

16 *When this letter is read among you, have it also read in the church of the Laodiceans; and you, for your part read my letter that is coming from Laodicea.*

17 *Say to Archippus, "Take heed to the ministry which you have received in the Lord, that you may fulfill it."*

18 *I, Paul, write this greeting with my own hand. Remember my imprisonment. Grace be with you.*

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② DEVOTIONAL

Personal preparation · Drawn from the outline of this study

No One Can Do It All

> *“Say to Archippus, “Take heed to the ministry which you have received in the Lord, that you may fulfill it.””*
>
> *— Colossians 4:17 (NASB95)*

The last verses of Colossians read like the closing credits of a film, and it is easy to skip them. But look closer, and you will see a family portrait. A trusted letter-carrier, a runaway slave turned faithful brother, a fellow prisoner, a young man who once quit and was restored, a doctor, a prayer warrior, a house church hosted by a woman named Nympha, and one man, Demas, whose name stands alone.

Paul could not do the work by himself, and neither can we. God uses ordinary people, people with a past, people with gifts, people with passion, and even people with weaknesses that will one day show. Every one of them had a place on the team.

And to one of them, Archippus, Paul sends a personal word: take heed to the ministry you have received in the Lord, and fulfill it. That word is for you too. Whatever God has given you to do, He will supply the grace to finish it. "Grace be with you."

For reflection

1. Which person in this portrait do you most identify with right now, and why?
2. What ministry have you "received in the Lord" that still needs to be fulfilled?
3. Is there a "Demas" tendency in you, a gradual love for this present world, that needs attention?

Christ is all, and in all, and He has a place for you on His team.

③ COMMENTARY

Teacher preparation resource · Full text organized under outline headings

> **The passage teaches:** Paul closes the letter by introducing the team God used to carry, support, and pray for His work: faithful messengers like Tychicus and Onesimus, Jewish and Gentile coworkers who comforted and strengthened him, and a family of churches charged to share the Word and fulfill their ministries, all sustained by the grace of God.

Outline

I. The Helpers God Uses (4:7–9)
- A. Tychicus: A Certain Kind of Helper (4:7)
- B. God Has a Purpose for the Helper (4:7–8)
- C. God Supplies Help for the Helper: Onesimus (4:9)

II. The Portrait of the Team (4:10–14)
- A. The Front Row: Jewish Coworkers (4:10–11)
- B. The Back Row: Gentile Coworkers (4:12–14)

III. Instructions to the Family (4:15–18)
- A. Care for One Another (4:15–16)
- B. Fulfill Your Ministry (4:17)
- C. Rest in God's Sufficiency (4:18)

Introduction

Most commentaries give these closing verses only a page or less, but they are full of valuable lessons. When Jesus gave the Great Commission, He spoke to a small band of men and told them to go into all the world. Two thousand years later the task is not yet finished, though we have moved a long way toward it. We will never reach the world by addition, but God's plan works by multiplication. If one person told one other, and those two each told one, and so on, the number would double each time, and in about a month the whole world would have heard.

No one person can possibly do the job. We all need to work, and we all need helpers. In these verses we see three things: the helpers God uses (vv.7–9), a portrait of the team (vv.10–14), and Paul's instructions to the family of churches (vv.15–18).

I. The Helpers God Uses (4:7–9)

A. Tychicus: A Certain Kind of Helper (4:7)

His name means "fortunate." Paul gives him three titles.

1. A beloved brother

Tychicus was a fellow believer from the province of Asia, and he had a long history with Paul. In the past he traveled with Paul on the third journey (Acts 20:4) and was with him in

Rome (Eph. 6:21–22). In the future he would serve Paul after his release from prison (Titus 3:12) and during his second Roman imprisonment (2 Tim. 4:12). He was beloved by Paul. They lived in close quarters in Rome, and in close quarters you either get along or get out.

2. A faithful servant

The New Testament has a rich vocabulary for servants, and each word has its own shade of meaning:

- *Diakonos*: the ministering servant (used here of Tychicus).
- *Oiketēs*: the household servant.
- *Hypēretēs*: the subordinate servant, originally an "under-rower."
- *Therapōn*: the attendant or confidential servant (Heb. 3:5).
- *Leitourgos*: the public servant (Rom. 13:6; Heb. 8:2).
- *Latreuō*: to render worshipful service (Phil. 3:3).
- *Oikonomos*: the steward, the responsible servant (1 Cor. 4:2).
- *Doulos*: the bond-servant (part of the next title).

"Faithful" means he could be trusted. He had been trusted with money, helping carry the collection to Jerusalem (Acts 20:4; 24:17), and now he was trusted with two letters, Colossians and Ephesians, and probably a third, to Philemon. Whom do you choose to carry inspired letters across the empire and bring back word from the churches: one who is expendable or one who is dependable? Tychicus was dependable. "Servant" here (*diakonos*) is used in its general sense, not the church office (compare Rom. 16:1).

3. A fellow bond-servant in the Lord

Syndoulos: the prefix *syn*, "with," shows that they were both slaves and on the same level. "In the Lord" shows whose slaves they were: not Caesar's, but Christ's. There is no hint of rivalry. They were on the same team, working for the same Master, striving toward the same goal.

B. God Has a Purpose for the Helper (4:7–8)

1. He carried the letter

Tychicus carried this letter to Colossae, and on the same trip carried Ephesians (Eph. 6:21–22). He carried precious content: the inspired Word of God. Did Paul know that? Yes: "the things which I write to you are the Lord's commandment" (1 Cor. 14:37). Peter knew it too, placing Paul's letters alongside "the rest of the Scriptures" (2 Pet. 3:16). Paul had no backup copy on a laptop. He trusted the Lord to keep the messenger and the message safe, and the Lord has preserved His Word to this day. In theology we call that the preservation of Scripture, alongside its inspiration and illumination.

2. He reported to them concerning Paul

"As to all my affairs, Tychicus … will bring you information." The Colossians were concerned about Paul and were praying for him, and knowing someone's circumstances helps us pray. The Roman authorities were unpredictable; Paul might be executed at any time. The Colossians would surely press Tychicus: "How is Paul, really? All he ever tells us is,

Rejoice!" Tychicus would tell them the truth, and Paul's attitude toward it. Paul did not send a pessimist. Like Joshua and Caleb, Tychicus could say, "Yes, there are giants, but the land flows with milk and honey, and the God who promised it will give it."

3. He would carry news both ways

"For I have sent him to you for this very purpose, that you may know about our circumstances" (NASB95; the NKJV reads "that he may know your circumstances"). Either way, information was to flow in both directions. Paul had not heard from Colossae since Epaphras arrived (1:7–8), and knowing that the apostle was asking for the details of their needs would itself have been a great comfort.

4. He would encourage their hearts

"And that he may encourage your hearts." Tychicus's presence, prayers, and counsel, along with Paul's letter read aloud, would strengthen and comfort them (compare 2:2).

C. God Supplies Help for the Helper: Onesimus (4:9)

"And with him Onesimus, our faithful and beloved brother, who is one of your number."

- **Help from an unlikely source.** Onesimus was a runaway slave from a Colossian household, the slave of Philemon. Everyone knew he had wronged his master and fled (Philem. 18). Under Roman law he could face severe punishment. What help could he be?
- **Help from a reliable source.** But now he is "our faithful and beloved brother." He ran to Rome to get lost in the crowd, and God found him there, brought him to Paul, and brought him to the gospel of God's grace (Philem. 10). He had been with Paul long enough to earn his trust. He was "one of your number," a Colossian, and now one of the family of God, forgiven.
- **An important part of the ministry.** "They will inform you about the whole situation here." There was safety in numbers on the dangerous roads. Onesimus carried a letter of his own, Paul's letter to Philemon. And when he stood before the church in Colossae, it may have been the first time he had ever spoken in a church. This time he had something to say.

II. The Portrait of the Team (4:10–14)

Picture a group photograph with two rows. In the front row stand three Jewish believers; in the back row, three Gentiles.

A. The Front Row: Jewish Coworkers (4:10–11)

1. Their general description

Their ethnicity. "These are the only fellow workers for the kingdom of God who are from the circumcision." Paul was the apostle to the Gentiles, but he never stopped loving his own people (Rom. 9:3), and his custom was to go to the synagogue first (Acts 17:1–2). The word "only" refers to his Jewish fellow workers; he had Gentile coworkers too (v.14; Philem. 24).

Their encouragement. "They have proved to be an encouragement to me." The word (*parēgoria*) means comfort, consolation, something that soothes. Some may remember an old stomach remedy called paregoric, named from this word. But we should not let later English usage define a Greek word. The same is true of *dynamis*, "power." When Alfred Nobel named his new explosive "dynamite" in 1867, he borrowed the Greek word, but that does not mean the gospel is "the power of God" (Rom. 1:16) in the sense of blowing people up. Those who help in the work of the gospel are a comfort to the leader.

2. Their individual description

Aristarchus: the man with a heart. "My fellow prisoner." A Macedonian from Thessalonica, he was seized by the mob during the riot in Ephesus (Acts 19:29). He traveled with the collection to Jerusalem (Acts 20:4) and sailed with Paul to Rome, sharing the shipwreck (Acts 27:2). He was with Paul still (Philem. 24). Whether he was literally imprisoned or voluntarily shared Paul's confinement, he was a burden-bearer. When you share that much hardship together, you lean on each other.

Mark: the man with a future. "Barnabas's cousin Mark (about whom you received instructions; if he comes to you, welcome him)." Mark had a past. He began the first missionary journey with Paul and Barnabas and then turned back (Acts 13:13). When Paul planned the second journey, Barnabas wanted to take Mark, and Paul said no. The disagreement was so sharp that two mission teams went in different directions (Acts 15:37–40). Was Mark finished? Does God judge a person by first failures? Think of Peter, or Jonah. It is not Mark's past that commends him to us; it is his future. He would write the Gospel of Mark. And near the end of his life Paul wrote, "Pick up Mark and bring him with you, for he is useful to me for service" (2 Tim. 4:11).

We cannot write a Gospel, but in a sense we are one. As an old poem puts it: "You are writing a Gospel, a chapter each day, by the deeds that you do and the words that you say. Men read what you write, whether faithless or true. Say, what is the Gospel according to you?"

Jesus called Justus: the man with a name. "Jesus" is the Greek form of the Hebrew Joshua, "the Lord is salvation" (Matt. 1:21). It was a common name in first-century Israel, and it became much less common among Jews and Christians once Jesus of Nazareth brought such distinction to it, which may be why this man went by Justus, "righteous." In some manuscripts of Matthew 27:16–17, noted already by Origen, Barabbas is called "Jesus Barabbas," and "Barabbas" means "son of the father." If so, Pilate's question was striking: "Whom do you want me to release for you, Jesus Barabbas, or Jesus who is called Christ?"

B. The Back Row: Gentile Coworkers (4:12–14)

1. Their general description

Their ethnicity. These men came from pagan backgrounds. Paul had to bring them from idolatry to the gospel of the grace of God, weaning them from their works just as Jewish believers had to be weaned from theirs. Peter opened the door to the Gentiles (Acts 10) and defended it (Acts 11). Paul had to correct Peter's conduct in Antioch (Gal. 2:11–14), and the

Jerusalem council agreed that Gentiles need not be circumcised (Acts 15). So Paul's team included Gentiles on equal footing.

Their familiarity. At least one of them, Epaphras, was "one of your number," a Colossian. The church would love to hear about him and his new friends.

2. Their individual description

Epaphras: the man with a passion (vv.12–13). "A bondslave of Jesus Christ … always laboring earnestly for you in his prayers, that you may stand perfect and fully assured in all the will of God." "Laboring earnestly" is one word, *agōnizomenos*, the same word Paul used of his own striving (1:29). Epaphras was far from Colossae, but there is no distance in prayer. He needed no expensive equipment, only a heart and a voice. And what a prayer! You cannot pray a better prayer for someone than that they may stand mature and fully assured in all the will of God. His "deep concern" (*ponos*, painful toil) reached beyond Colossae to Laodicea and Hierapolis. Philemon 23 calls him Paul's "fellow prisoner."

Luke: the man with a gift (v.14a). "Luke, the beloved physician." Luke was a doctor, and he was also a careful historian. He wrote the Gospel that bears his name and the book of Acts, researching the facts (Luke 1:1–4) under the guidance of the Holy Spirit. His medical skill no doubt helped Paul through many physical hardships. In Acts we can trace Luke's presence by the "we" passages (for example, Acts 16:10; 20:5; 27:1). He was with Paul to the end (2 Tim. 4:11, "Only Luke is with me").

Demas: the man with a weakness (v.14b). "And also Demas." That is all. No "beloved," no "faithful," no description. We should not read too much into that silence, except for what Paul wrote a few years later:

> *“for Demas, having loved this present world, has deserted me and gone to Thessalonica; Crescens has gone to Galatia, Titus to Dalmatia.”*
>
> — 2 Timothy 4:10 (NASB95)

Were there already signs of cooling? His problem was "this present world." That kind of drift seldom strikes all at once. It comes gradually, from some root that allows the world to take control. John warns:

> *“Do not love the world nor the things in the world. If anyone loves the world, the love of the Father is not in him. For all that is in the world, the lust of the flesh and the lust of the eyes and the boastful pride of life, is not from the Father, but is from the world.”*
>
> — 1 John 2:15–16 (NASB95)

And Jesus prayed for His disciples, and for us: "I do not ask You to take them out of the world, but to keep them from the evil one" (John 17:15).

III. Instructions to the Family (4:15–18)

A. Care for One Another (4:15–16)

1. Greet the brethren

"Greet the brethren who are in Laodicea." "Brethren" (*adelphoi*) literally means "from the same womb," born of the same parent. We are born of God by grace through faith in Christ. Today we use "brother" in church so often it can become a formality, but for the early Christians it was a precious reality. Paul had already taught them: "while we have opportunity, let us do good to all people, and especially to those who are of the household of the faith" (Gal. 6:10).

Members of Christ's body are to "have the same care for one another" (1 Cor. 12:25), no matter how different their characters, gifts, or functions. Paul likens the church to the human body. If something gets into the eye, the most delicate organ, the hand, the most ordinary, comes to its rescue. "The eye cannot say to the hand, 'I have no need of you'" (1 Cor. 12:21). Neither should there be envy or self-pity: "If the ear says, 'Because I am not an eye, I am not a part of the body,' it is not for this reason any the less a part of the body" (1 Cor. 12:16). Early observers of the Church are said to have remarked, "See how these Christians love one another."

2. The church in a house

"And also Nympha and the church that is in her house." (The NASB95 reads "Nympha … her house"; the NKJV reads "Nymphas … his house," following other manuscripts.) The early church did not meet in special buildings; it met in homes (Rom. 16:5; 1 Cor. 16:19; Philem. 2). The word "church" has several uses: the local congregation in a certain place; the universal body of Christ, composed of all believers from Pentecost to the Rapture; and, in our day, the building where a church meets. Peter reminds us that the true building is spiritual: "you also, as living stones, are being built up as a spiritual house for a holy priesthood" (1 Pet. 2:5).

3. Read the letters

"When this letter is read among you, have it also read in the church of the Laodiceans; and you, for your part read my letter that is coming from Laodicea." Paul's letters were meant to circulate. As noted earlier, the Laodicean letter may well have been Ephesians.

A sobering note: some three decades later, the risen Lord sent the church at Laodicea one of His sternest messages (Rev. 3:14–22). There was no enthusiasm: "neither cold nor hot." There was no sense of need: "I have need of nothing." And Christ Himself stood outside, knocking: "If anyone hears My voice and opens the door, I will come in to him and will dine with him." That invitation is addressed to a church, to believers who had lost fellowship with Christ, rather than being primarily an evangelistic appeal. Deficiency is possible even in a church that once received a letter from Paul.

B. Fulfill Your Ministry (4:17)

"Say to Archippus, 'Take heed to the ministry which you have received in the Lord, that you may fulfill it.'" This is a personal message to one man, delivered publicly. Archippus is also named in Philemon 2 as a "fellow soldier," perhaps a member of Philemon's household.

- **Its significance.** "Take heed" means pay close attention. Perhaps Archippus was serving in Epaphras's place while Epaphras was in Rome, an interim pastor, we might say. Paul wants him to carry the responsibility faithfully.
- **Its source.** "Which you have received in the Lord." His ministry was a trust from the Lord, and one day he would answer to the Lord for it.
- **Its success.** "That you may fulfill it." Not half-heartedly, but to the full.

What is your calling from God? If God calls us to a task, He equips us for it. When God called Moses, Moses objected that he was slow of speech. God already knew that, and He answered, "I will be with you" (Exod. 3:12) and "I, even I, will be with your mouth" (Exod. 4:12). To Gideon He said, "Go in this your strength … Have I not sent you?" (Judg. 6:14).

C. Rest in God's Sufficiency (4:18)

1. The letter is authentic

"I, Paul, write this greeting with my own hand." Paul usually dictated his letters to a secretary (Rom. 16:22) and then signed the closing himself as proof of authenticity: "this is a distinguishing mark in every letter; this is the way I write" (2 Thess. 3:17).

2. The chains are real

"Remember my imprisonment." Paul does not complain. He had many needs, but he simply asks to be remembered, surely in prayer. In Philippians he mentions that some even sought to add to his distress in his imprisonment (Phil. 1:17).

3. The grace is abounding

"Grace be with you." Paul knew grace well. He begins and ends every letter with it. Of his own ministry he wrote:

> *“But by the grace of God I am what I am, and His grace toward me did not prove vain; but I labored even more than all of them, yet not I, but the grace of God with me.”*
>
> — 1 Corinthians 15:10 (NASB95)

Paul's past was a backdrop on which God displayed His grace. He traveled farther, suffered more opposition, wrote more New Testament letters, and planted more churches than any other apostle, yet he knew it was God's power, not his own, that produced the results. "Where sin increased, grace abounded all the more" (Rom. 5:20).

Conclusion

These closing verses are brief, but they teach us much. We are not promised an easy road; there may be deficiency even in good churches. There must be faithfulness; each of us has a ministry received in the Lord to fulfill, and if our part is left undone, other parts of the work

will lack. But we are not left alone. God supplies helpers, and His grace is with us every step of the way.

We are not what we were. We are what we are. We shall be what we will be, all by the super-abounding grace of God. Christ is all, and in all.

Lord, thank You.

④ SELF-STUDY GUIDE

For use during the group meeting · Focused on the commentary text

Greek Word Study

Grammar and parsing: Blue Letter Bible. Sources cited selectively: STR (Strong's), THAY (Thayer's), ATR (A. T. Robertson), VINE (Vine's), MRV (Vincent's), LXX (Septuagint usage).

Verse	Greek Word (Lexical Form) / English	Strong's # / Transliteration / Form	Definition & Significance
v.7	**ἀγαπητός** *beloved*	**G27** *agapētos* Nom. Masc. Sg.	**STR:** beloved, dear. **Significance:** Ministry partnership rooted in genuine love.
v.7	**διάκονος** *servant*	**G1249** *diakonos* Nom. Masc. Sg.	**VINE:** a ministering servant; general, not the church office here. **Significance:** Tychicus served faithfully as a trusted messenger.
v.7	**σύνδουλος** *fellow bond-servant*	**G4889** *syndoulos* Nom. Masc. Sg.	**STR:** a co-slave of the same master. **Significance:** Same Master, same level, same goal, no rivalry.
v.8	**παρακαλέω** *encourage*	**G3870** *parakaleō* Aor. Act. Subj. 3rd Sg.	**THAY:** to comfort, strengthen, exhort (cf. 2:2). **Significance:** Part of Tychicus's mission: strengthen their hearts.
v.10	**συναιχμάλωτος** *fellow prisoner*	**G4869** *synaichmalōtos* Nom. Masc. Sg.	**MRV:** literally a fellow prisoner of war. **Significance:** Aristarchus shared Paul's captivity.
v.10	**ἀνεψιός** *cousin*	**G431** *anepsios* Nom. Masc. Sg.	**STR:** a cousin. Only here in the NT. **Significance:** Explains Barnabas's commitment to Mark (Acts 15:37–39).
v.11	**συνεργός** *fellow workers*	**G4904** *synergos* Nom. Masc. Pl.	**VINE:** a co-worker, helper in a common task. **Significance:** Each had a share in the work of the kingdom.
v.11	**παρηγορία** *encouragement*	**G3931** *parēgoria* Nom. Fem. Sg.	**THAY:** comfort, solace. Only here in the NT. **Significance:** Faithful coworkers soothe and strengthen a leader.
v.12	**ἀγωνίζομαι** *laboring earnestly*	**G75** *agōnizomai* Pres. Mid. Ptc. Nom. Masc. Sg.	**VINE:** to contend, agonize (cf. 1:29; 2:1). **Significance:** Epaphras prayed with athletic intensity.
v.12	**πληροφορέω** *fully assured*	**G4135** *plērophoreō* Perf. Pass. Ptc. Nom. Masc. Pl.	**THAY:** to be fully persuaded, filled with conviction. **Significance:** Epaphras prayed for settled conviction in God's will (cf. 2:2).
v.13	**πόνος** *deep concern*	**G4192** *ponos* Acc. Masc. Sg.	**STR:** toil, pain, anguish. **Significance:** Prayer ministry that costs the one who prays.

Verse	Greek Word (Lexical Form) / English	Strong's # / Transliteration / Form	Definition & Significance
v.14	**ἰατρός** *physician*	**G2395** *iatros* Nom. Masc. Sg.	**STR:** a physician. **Significance:** Luke used his professional gift in service to Paul and the gospel.
v.17	**διακονία** *ministry*	**G1248** *diakonia* Acc. Fem. Sg.	**VINE:** service, ministry entrusted to someone. **Significance:** Archippus's ministry was "received in the Lord."
v.18	**μνημονεύω** *remember*	**G3421** *mnēmoneuō* Pres. Act. Imp. 2nd Pl.	**THAY:** to be mindful of, keep in mind. **Significance:** Keep Paul's chains in mind, especially in prayer.

Grammar key — Cases: Nom. · Gen. · Dat. · Acc. · Voc. | Number: Sg. · Pl. | Gender: Masc. · Fem. · Neut. Verb Mood: Ind. · Imp. · Subj. · Opt. · Inf. · Ptc. | Tense: Pres. · Imperf. · Fut. · Aor. · Perf. · Plpf. | Voice: Act. · Mid. · Pass. | Person: 1st/2nd/3rd Sg./Pl.

Study Questions

Part 1 — From the Commentary

Review prompt	From the commentary
Give Tychicus's three titles.	Beloved brother, faithful servant, fellow bond-servant in the Lord.
Why was Onesimus an unlikely helper?	He was a runaway slave who had wronged his master; now a faithful, beloved brother.
Who stood in the "front row," and who in the "back row"?	Front (Jewish): Aristarchus, Mark, Justus. Back (Gentile): Epaphras, Luke, Demas.
What lesson does Mark's life teach?	God does not judge a person by first failures; Mark became "useful … for service" (2 Tim. 4:11).
What three things mark Paul's final verse?	Authentic signature, remembered chains, abounding grace.

Part 2 — Study Questions

1. What does Tychicus teach about the kind of helper God uses?

> **Leader's answer:** He was beloved, faithful, and humble, a dependable servant trusted with money and with inspired letters, serving on the same level as Paul under the same Master.

2. How does Onesimus's story display the grace of God?

> **Leader's answer:** A runaway slave who had wronged his master was found by God in Rome, saved through Paul, and sent home as a faithful, beloved brother and trusted messenger. God's grace

transforms people with a past into partners in ministry.

3. What warning does Demas give us, and how does 1 John 2:15–16 help explain it?

Leader's answer: Demas later deserted Paul, "having loved this present world." Love for the world usually grows gradually through the lust of the flesh, the lust of the eyes, and the boastful pride of life. Believers must guard against that slow drift.

4. How does Epaphras show the power and priority of prayer?

Leader's answer: Far from home, he labored earnestly in prayer for the churches, asking that they would stand mature and fully assured in God's will. Prayer needs no special equipment and knows no distance.

5. What does the charge to Archippus teach about ministry, and what assurance does Scripture give those whom God calls?

Leader's answer: Ministry is received from the Lord, must be taken seriously, and should be fulfilled completely. God equips those He calls, as He promised Moses, "I will be with you … with your mouth," and His grace is sufficient.

Part 3 — Passage Summary

Verses	Theme	Key truth
4:7–9	The helpers	Tychicus and Onesimus carry the letter, report on Paul, and encourage the church.
4:10–11	The front row	Aristarchus, Mark, and Justus, Jewish coworkers who comfort Paul.
4:12–14	The back row	Epaphras the prayer warrior, Luke the physician, and Demas.
4:15–17	The family	Greet the brethren, read the letters, and fulfill your ministry.
4:18	The close	Paul's own signature, his chains, and grace.

⑤ APPLICATION

Closes the study · personal and corporate

1. Be Dependable

Scripture anchor: Colossians 4:7; 1 Corinthians 4:2

Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, I.A

Tychicus was not famous, but he was faithful. God's work moves forward on the shoulders of dependable people who show up, carry what is entrusted to them, and do it well. "It is required of stewards that one be found trustworthy."

Reflection: Is there a responsibility you have been careless with?

Practical step: Identify one commitment at church or home you have neglected and complete it this week.

2. Give People a Second Chance

Scripture anchor: Colossians 4:9–10; 2 Timothy 4:11

Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, I.C and II.A.2

Onesimus and Mark both had failures in their past, yet both became valued members of Paul's team. Grace restores. We should be quick to welcome and encourage believers who have stumbled and are seeking to serve again.

Reflection: Is there someone you have written off because of past failure?

Practical step: Reach out to encourage one believer who is trying to make a fresh start.

3. Labor in Prayer for Others

Scripture anchor: Colossians 4:12–13

Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, II.B.2, and ④ Study Question 4

Epaphras's great ministry was prayer. Anyone can have this ministry, regardless of age, health, or location. Pray Epaphras's prayer for others: that they may stand mature and fully assured in all the will of God.

Reflection: Who are you "laboring earnestly" for in prayer?

Practical step: Pray Colossians 4:12 by name for five people every day this week.

4. Fulfill Your Ministry by Grace

Scripture anchor: Colossians 4:17–18; 1 Corinthians 15:10

Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, III.B–C; cf. Bing, Simply by Grace (FGR)

Every believer has received a ministry in the Lord. Charles Bing reminds us that grace not only saves us freely but also motivates and enables our service. We serve not to earn God's favor but because we have it, and we will one day give an account to the Lord who gave the ministry.

Reflection: What has the Lord given you to do that you have not yet fully done?

Practical step: Write down your ministry in one sentence, share it with your group, and ask them to hold you accountable to fulfill it.

End of Study · Colossians 4:7–18